

Simple Steps to Help You Install gVim on Windows 7

Vim is a text editor that is based on the Vi editor, which is common to UNIX-like systems. gVim is the GUI version of Vim. This article is a detailed account on how to install gVim on a Windows 7 machine along with Git, Pathogen and plugins.



I had used Vim on Linux earlier, but what I did was pretty basic. About two months ago, out of the blue, I installed it on Windows 7 on my work laptop and started trying it out. The initial days were filled with frustration and confusion but a few weeks later, I started getting comfortable. I am glad I stuck with it as a recent task at work involved verifying, editing, searching and replacing a lot of commands and scripts, and without gVim, it would have taken me at least twice as long.

Vim's power and flexibility is further enhanced by the plugins. All thanks to Git and Pathogen, installing plugins is now a breeze. However, there isn't any step-by-step guide on the Internet that shows you how to do it for gVim on Windows 7. I had to scour the Net, get information in bits and pieces and, often, there were just fleeting references on how to install it on Windows. It took me some time to figure things out and I initially wrote this article as a reference for myself. I kept adding steps to it and eventually thought it might also help others.

A note before we proceed. I am not at all a Vim expert. I just started using it about two months ago so the steps given below aren't exactly the 'one true way' of doing it. If you know a better way of doing things or feel that it can be improved, please let me know.

Just to ensure that the steps given here work fine, I completely uninstalled gVim, Git and Pathogen, and as I

reinstalled them, I took screenshots, captured the command line outputs and wrote the article.

The sequence of events

- 1) Download Vim and install it, move/delete a few folders (directories).
- 2) Next, install Git and Pathogen, which will make installing/uninstalling the Vim plugins easy. We'll also add a few settings in the `_vimrc` file.
- 3) Install a few colour scheme plugins.

Basically, when you install gVim, it will look like what's shown in Figure 1.

It's fairly plain and simple, and could use a better font and background; so let's tweak it and after we are done, it'll look like what's shown in Figure 2.

Note, Vim will work from the command prompt (Console version) but this article focuses on gVim.

gVim installation

You can download gVim from www.vim.org. In fact, right on the home page, you'll find a link to download the Windows version.

After downloading it, you can install it as usual in the `C:\Program Files (x86)` directory, but it's better to install it in your home directory. In my case, this is `C:\Users\Admin`. Create a folder called 'Vim' under your